All Will Be Forgiven?

Compassion, a Warning, and Our Shared Humanity

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> *"Truly I tell you, people can be forgiven all their sins and every slander they utter, but whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit will never be forgiven; they are guilty of an eternal sin."*
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> — Mark 3:28–29, New International Version (2011).[1]

1. Hearing the warning

In the span of a single breath, this remarkable saying opens forgiveness across the range of human sin and slander, then names a stark exception. Read as two detached statements, the words seem to pull us in opposite directions. Heard together, they may do something more: the expansiveness of the first makes the expression that follows all the more startling. Against the possibility of forgiveness for so much, Jesus places the gravity of what his hearers are saying. Perhaps that contrast is part of the force with which he is trying to reach them.[2]

Mark places these words in an encounter with scribes who have attributed Jesus's healing work to demonic power. Are these words intended as a sharp warning, an effort to awaken those making the accusation, or perhaps to disrupt the harmful judgment itself? They may further serve as a warning to others witnessing the exchange. Jesus uses the language of judgment to challenge a judgment that turns the source of healing into an enemy. The severity draws attention to what that reversal means. A warning may carry compassion without sounding reassuring, and its care may extend beyond the people it directly addresses to those who could be affected by their words.

What the words declare, what speaking them seeks to accomplish, and what eventually happens to those addressed are related but distinct. A warning can seek to prevent a loss that the speaker regards as final; it can also confront a refusal that might yet change. Mark gives us the declaration and the encounter, not the hearers' final history.

We also bring our own histories to these words. Forgiveness may suggest pardon, release, or reconciliation; judgment may suggest discernment or condemnation. Jesus and those who heard him spoke from their own inherited language and religious life. As their exchange is remembered, written, translated, and taught, it enters other lives and other

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[1] Biblica, *Holy Bible, New International Version* (2011), Mark 3:28–29. Scripture quotations marked NIV use this edition throughout. The close renderings below are supplied from the Greek rather than substituted for the NIV wording.

[2] Mark 3:22–30. The universal wording in verse 28 concerns human sins and blasphemies; verse 29 immediately qualifies it. It does not independently establish the final salvation of every person.

circumstances. What changes when words spoken to particular people become a judgment we pronounce about someone else—or an entire community?

Teachings from other traditions can make familiar assumptions visible. The Gospels themselves challenge the assumption that faith and mercy will appear only within our own community. Jesus responds to a centurion's trust with astonishment: "I have not found anyone in Israel with such great faith" (Matthew 8:10, NIV). In Luke's parable of the Good Samaritan, the compassionate action comes from a Samaritan, a member of a related but contested Israelite tradition: he sees the wounded man and "took pity on him" (Luke 10:33, NIV). Jesus directs attention toward faith and compassionate action where his hearers might not expect to find them.[3]

Jewish teaching has an indispensable place in this inquiry, both as Jesus's own religious inheritance and as a continuing voice with questions of its own. The Mishnah preserves rejected opinions of Hillel and Shammai, Jewish teachers associated with the period around the beginning of the Common Era, to teach that a person should not insist on their own position (Eduyot 1:4). Much later, the British rabbi and public thinker Jonathan Sacks (1948–2020) describes the ideal exemplified by Hillel's school: "They sought truth, not victory." The willingness to be corrected belongs here within a committed religious life. Fidelity to a teaching need not become the need to defend ourselves.[4]

Islam speaks from a shared Abrahamic inheritance, with its own understanding of revelation and guidance. The Qur'an names Abraham, Moses, and Jesus within that inheritance. Elsewhere it describes those who turn toward God through the way they listen:

> "Who listen to speech and follow the best of it. Those are the ones Allāh has guided, and those are people of understanding."
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> — Qur'an 39:18, Saheeh International translation.[5]

Listening is joined here with discernment and response. What we hear is not simply something to possess; it asks something of how we understand and live.

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[3] Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 10:25–37. The Samaritan in Luke's parable represents a real religious and social boundary within an intertwined Israelite inheritance, not a wholly unrelated religion. The comparison concerns recognition and compassionate action across an expected boundary; it does not establish that every religious claim is equally true.

[4] Mishnah Eduyot 1:4, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre. The explanation concerns preserving opinions that did not become the accepted ruling; it commends learning and correction within legal deliberation. Jonathan Sacks, "Argument for the Sake of Heaven," *Covenant & Conversation*, Korach, paragraph following his quotation of Eruvin 13b; biographical orientation from The Rabbi Sacks Legacy. Sacks discusses Avot and Eruvin, not Eduyot. These later witnesses do not establish what the scribes in Mark believed or prove a historical connection with Buddhist nonattachment.

[5] Qur'an 39:18, Saheeh International, read with 39:17 and its description of turning toward God. The wording quoted is the complete verse in that translation. Compare 2:136 for the named prophetic inheritance. Interpretations differ over whether "speech" means what one hears more broadly or specifically revealed teaching; the verse is not presented as an unqualified endorsement of religious pluralism. No exhaustive tafsir study is claimed.

Attachment to a view can also be examined from beyond this shared inheritance. The Vietnamese Buddhist monastic and peace activist Thích Nhất Hạnh (1926–2022) joined contemplative practice with responding to suffering, establishing the Order of Interbeing. His tradition asks how a teaching can become something we defend without allowing it to change us. Its commitment to nonattachment includes Buddhist teachings themselves. Listening and deep looking concern not only what we believe, but how we come to see—and what that seeing makes possible in our lives.[6]

2. A teacher among people

The story before the saying

In Mark's opening chapter, the Spirit descends upon Jesus, who later proclaims that "The kingdom of God has come near" (1:15, NIV). Teaching, healing, and release from impure spirits give that proclamation a visible form. People gather around him; he also withdraws to pray. From the beginning, the Gospel presents divine activity through a life moving among other lives, not through a list of propositions delivered outside any human setting.[7]

Questions develop around what this activity means. When Jesus forgives a paralyzed man, some *grammateis*—scribes, or learned interpreters of Torah—think, "He's blaspheming!" (2:7, NIV). His meals with people identified as sinners, and his disciples' conduct on the Sabbath, bring further challenges. Jesus responds through questions and images, including the physician who attends the sick and new wine that cannot be contained in old wineskins (2:17–22). Jesus and those questioning him share a Jewish scriptural world in which mercy, Torah, interpretation, and faithfulness already matter deeply. Their disagreements concern how that inheritance is being lived.[8]

Sabbath observance belongs to that inheritance. In the Torah it is holy rest, extending to servants, resident foreigners, and animals; Deuteronomy also recalls liberation from slavery. Torah gives form to religious and communal life, and living by its commandments requires interpretation. When chapter 3 opens with a man whose hand needs healing, some of those present watch to see whether Jesus will heal on the Sabbath so that they can accuse him. Here the question concerns what faithfulness to Sabbath rest asks when a person before them needs healing. Jesus asks about doing good and saving life; the

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[6] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, First–Third Trainings; Plum Village's biography of Thích Nhất Hạnh. He was a Vietnamese monk and teacher, founded the Order in 1966, and developed Plum Village in France from 1982 with his community. The Jewish sources developed below belong to different periods, not a single reconstructed first-century position. A later Islamic comparison is likewise not evidence of influence on Jesus.

[7] Mark 1:9–15, 21–39. This is the Gospel's narrated sequence, not an independently recovered chronology of Jesus's ministry.

[8] Mark 2:1–28. In 2:6 the Greek noun is γραμματεῖς, *grammateis*, conventionally rendered "scribes"; the NIV's "teachers of the law" is an interpretive English rendering. The NABRE describes scribes as trained in oral interpretation of written Torah. Torah encompasses religious and communal obligations; the prose does not deny its legal dimensions. In 2:1–12 the accusation of blasphemy concerns Jesus's authority to forgive sins; the accusation in 3:22 concerns the source of his power over demons.

response is silence. Mark describes him as angry and "deeply distressed at their stubborn hearts" (3:5, NIV), then shows him restoring the man's hand.[9]

Later, so many people gather that Jesus and those with him cannot eat, and his family comes to take charge of him (3:20–21). Even those closest to him struggle to understand what is happening. The difficulty of receiving him reaches into family and community as well as religious debate. The saying about forgiveness emerges from this crowded, unsettled human world.

Mercy and warning within the Jewish inheritance

The scriptures shared by Jesus and those questioning him hold mercy and the consequences of wrongdoing in close relation. In Exodus's proclamation of the divine name, God is "compassionate and gracious," "abounding in love and faithfulness," and "forgiving wickedness, rebellion and sin" (34:6–7, NIV). The same passage refuses to treat wrongdoing as inconsequential and speaks in difficult language about guilt and consequences across generations. Compassion here is not indifference to harm; mercy and accountability are held together within the same sacred language.[10]

Ezekiel gives severe warning an explicitly life-seeking purpose. God declares, "I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked," then calls, "Turn! Turn from your evil ways!" (33:11, NIV). The following verses connect turning with restitution and changed conduct. The warning names a real danger, and the call to change is equally real. This does not decide the meaning of Mark's exception. It locates concern, judgment, and the possibility of turning within a Jewish scriptural inheritance that Jesus and his hearers share.[11]

From accusation to warning

The scribes who arrive from Jerusalem give Jesus's work a particularly damaging interpretation: "By the prince of demons he is driving out demons" (3:22, NIV). They associate his power with Beelzebul, the ruler of demons. They are not simply denying that something has happened. They name its source as evil.[12]

Jesus calls them over and asks, "How can Satan drive out Satan?" (3:23, NIV). A divided kingdom or household cannot stand; taking a strong man's possessions requires first overcoming him. These images challenge the accusation at its center. In Mark's telling, Jesus is breaking the hold of destructive power, not serving it. He addresses those making the accusation with reasons and images through which they might reconsider. The summons

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[9] Exodus 20:8–11; Deuteronomy 5:12–15; Mark 3:1–6. Compare the later permission to treat danger to life in Mishnah Yoma 8:6. That later formulation should not be projected backward as a complete description of the dispute over the non-emergency healing narrated by Mark.

[10] Exodus 34:6–7. The proclamation also describes consequences extending across generations. Its difficult account of responsibility must not be reduced to a modern therapeutic understanding of forgiveness.

[11] Ezekiel 33:7–20, especially 11, 14–16. Repentance here includes returning what was taken and acting justly; the call to turn is not detached from changed conduct.

[12] Mark 3:22–30. The narrative sequence is accusation, summons and parabolic response, then warning; verse 30 explains the warning by the accusation. No intervening reply is recorded.

keeps the exchange an act of address, even amid sharp disagreement. Mark does not report how they receive this argument; the next recorded words sharpen the address.

The address then turns to the warning with which we began. Mark connects it directly with their accusation: "He has an impure spirit" (3:30, NIV). The source of the work he presents as holy is being named evil. This is not a general disagreement about religious language; it concerns whether the healing taking place before them is to be welcomed or opposed.

There is a further reversal across these chapters. Earlier, Jesus is accused of blasphemy because he forgives. Now he uses the language of judgment to challenge the claim that his healing work comes from evil. Words his hearers take seriously are turned toward their own interpretation of what is happening. On this reading, the warning confronts the rejection of the very source from which healing and forgiveness might be received.[13]

The scribes are the immediate addressees: Mark says that Jesus calls them over. Yet the exchange is framed by a crowd gathering around him (3:20) and a crowd seated around him afterward (3:32). His words may work within that wider circle as well. An accusation about the source of healing can shape more than the convictions of those who make it; it can influence what others fear, whom they trust, and whether they approach the one offering help. On this reading, interrupting the accusation also serves those whose possibilities it might close. The narrative makes that wider effect plausible without telling us that Jesus addresses every person present or how anyone responds.[14]

Disruption without retaliation

Walter Wink, a twentieth- and early-twenty-first-century American biblical scholar, approaches Jesus's teaching on nonviolence as an alternative to both submission and violent retaliation. In his reading of Matthew's turning-the-cheek, cloak, and second-mile sayings, people resist a degrading relationship without accepting violence as their only means of resistance. He writes, "Loving confrontation can free both the oppressed from docility and the oppressor from sin." Yet he also warns that nonviolent action can be used for revenge and humiliation. Refusing physical violence does not, by itself, establish a loving purpose.[15]

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[13] Compare Mark 2:7 with 3:22–30. The account of corrective purpose is an interpretation of the encounter, not an additional statement about Jesus's inward intention supplied by the narrator.

[14] Mark 3:20–35, especially 20, 22–23, and 31–32. The scribes are the immediate referent of "them" in verse 23. The surrounding crowd supplies a narrative basis for considering wider effects; the text neither lists everyone who heard the warning nor records the response of the crowd or scribes. The possibility that the speech interrupts an accusation's influence is an interpretive proposal, not an additional narrated event.

[15] Walter Wink, *Jesus and Nonviolence: A Third Way*, (Fortress Press, 2003), ch. 2, pp. 25–28, quotation at 26. The comparison draws on his distinction between active nonviolent confrontation, retaliatory humiliation, and passivity, not on every detail of his reconstruction of Matthew 5. In "Beyond Just War and Pacifism: Jesus' Nonviolent Way," section "Beyond Just War and Pacifism," Wink explicitly allows nonviolent pressure that compels unwelcome choices. His account should not be equated with the absence of coercive pressure or with the Buddhist commitment not to impose beliefs. The application to Mark 3 is proposed here, not attributed to Wink.

Wink's discussion concerns Jesus's teaching on retaliation in Matthew 5:38–42, within the Sermon on the Mount, not this passage in Mark. It nevertheless opens a way of attending to the encounter. Jesus refuses the interpretation imposed on his work and brings its consequences into question. He does not need to leave the accusation unanswered in order to refrain from retaliation. A sharp disruption may protect the possibility of healing for others as well as challenge those speaking against it. Care for a person and resistance to what the person is doing can belong to one action.

The severity makes this a demanding possibility, not an easy description. A threat of unforgivable sin can itself be used to silence dissent or secure obedience. Calling it nonviolent would explain nothing if the result were simply to sanctify intimidation. The question is whether the warning exposes a real harm and interrupts its power without making the people responsible disposable. We can hear a possible act of compassion here while continuing to ask what distinguishes truthful, protective confrontation from the religious use of fear.

A saying that unsettles its hearers

Seen together, the summons, the parables, and the warning suggest a form of teaching that aims not only to rebut an accusation but to interrupt a way of seeing. The words work within relationship: they warn, rebuke, invite, unsettle, and ask the hearer to recognize something the present judgment has obscured. A teacher may speak within familiar categories in order to expose what those categories have prevented someone from noticing. That possibility does not place Jesus outside his own culture. It asks how he works within it, addressing particular people whose response matters.

This hearing also has a Christian precedent. John Chrysostom, a late-fourth-century preacher in Antioch, in Roman Syria, describes Jesus's purpose as "to do good to them that were sinning" (*Homily 41 on Matthew*, §1). Commenting on Matthew's parallel, he hears correction within confrontation. His interpretation retains severe judgment, but concern is not confined to reassuring speech.[16]

Koan practice, a form of contemplative inquiry in Zen, offers a related way of encountering challenging speech. A saying can interrupt the understanding with which we approach it, rather than supply an answer that leaves us unchanged. Thích Nhất Hạnh describes this involvement in *Bat Nha: a Koan*, where the question becomes one's "own problem." Applied here, the question is no longer only which other person falls under the warning. It includes the judgments through which we ourselves hear it. A conclusion about the scribes in the story may leave those judgments untouched; entering the question can make them

[16] John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 41.1, translated by George Prevost and revised by M. B. Riddle, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, first series, vol. 10 (1888). For Chrysostom's Antioch ministry, see Benedict XVI, "Saint John Chrysostom (1)," general audience, September 19, 2007.

visible. Jesus's response begins with parables, and the severe saying belongs to the same address.[17]

The human danger coming into view is not simply mistaken perception. It is clinging to a judgment so closely that we can no longer receive what might correct it. If liberation is named evil, liberation itself becomes something to resist. What could then be welcomed as healing? Mark does not explain the inner motives of those speaking, but his account makes this reversal of recognition visible. The possibility that such resistance can change remains a further question; its present seriousness does not by itself answer it.

3. Understanding the words

Jesus is responding to the judgment that his liberating work is evil. Careful study of the language keeps that setting in view. The Gospel of Mark is commonly dated around 70 CE and understood to have been composed in Greek, several decades after Jesus's ministry. That is a date for composition, not for the surviving copies, and a Greek composition is not a transcript of an earlier spoken encounter.

Mark preserves Aramaic words elsewhere, including "Talitha koum" in the raising of Jairus's daughter (5:41). First-century Palestine was multilingual: Aramaic was widely used, Hebrew remained in use, Greek was also present, and scholars differ over their relative roles. It is therefore plausible that Jesus knew and used more than one language, but the evidence does not identify the language of this exchange or of its earliest oral transmission. Nor has a lost Aramaic Gospel of Mark from which our Greek text was translated been established. The text below follows the *SBL Greek New Testament*, edited by Michael W. Holmes.[18]

The human work of translation was recognized within Jewish tradition. In the prologue to Ben Sira, a Jewish wisdom book also called Sirach, the translator observes that Hebrew expression "does not have exactly the same effect when translated into another language"

[17] Thích Nhất Hạnh, "Bat Nha: a Koan," opening account of koan practice. The comparison concerns how an inquiry includes the person undertaking it; it is not a claim that Mark belongs historically to the Zen genre or that Buddhist teaching influenced Jesus. "Contemplative" is used as a broad description, not an assertion that all Christian and Buddhist contemplative practices are identical.

[18] Michael W. Holmes, ed., *The Greek New Testament: SBL Edition* (2010), Mark 3:28–30. Mark 5:41 preserves "Talitha koum." On the multilingual setting, see Steven E. Fassberg, "Which Semitic Language Did Jesus and Other Contemporary Jews Speak?" *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 74.2 (2012), 263–280, and Stanley E. Porter, "Jesus and the Use of Greek: A Response to Maurice Casey," *Bulletin for Biblical Research* 10.1 (2000). Fassberg argues that Jesus's Aramaic is secure and that living Hebrew makes Hebrew competence highly likely; Porter argues for a greater role for Greek. These positions do not identify the language of Mark 3. For Palestinian Aramaic and later Syriac, see the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon's "The Aramaic Language." A critical Greek edition reconstructs a written text from witnesses; it is not an autograph or transcript of Jesus's speech.

(prologue, lines 21–22, NRSVUE). This is not a reason to abandon the words. It is a reason to study them in relation to the life, language, and practice through which they are transmitted.[19]

Interpreting the passage

Mark 3:28

Greek: Ἀμὴν λέγω ὑμῖν ὅτι πάντα ἀφεθήσεται τοῖς υἱοῖς τῶν ἀνθρώπων, τὰ ἁμαρτήματα καὶ αἱ βλασφημίαι ὅσα ἐὰν βλασφημήσωσιν·

Romanization: *Amēn legō hymin hoti panta aphethēsetai tois huiois tōn anthrōpōn, ta hamartēmata kai hai blasphēmiai hosa ean blasphēmēsōsin.*

Literal English: “Truly I say to you that all [πάντα, *panta*: all] will be forgiven [ἀφεθήσεται, *aphethēsetai*: will be forgiven] to the sons of human beings [τοῖς υἱοῖς τῶν ἀνθρώπων, *tois huiois tōn anthrōpōn*: to human beings / humanity]: the sins and the blasphemies, whatever they may blaspheme.”

The Greek verb is “will be forgiven”; the NIV opening renders the statement “can be forgiven.” The entire movement matters, rather than any isolated phrase.[20]

Mark 3:29

Greek: ὃς δ’ ἂν βλασφημήσῃ εἰς τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον, οὐκ ἔχει ἄφεσιν εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, ἀλλὰ ἔνοχός ἐστιν αἰωνίου ἁμαρτήματος.

Romanization: *Hos d’ an blasphēmēsē eis to pneuma to hagion, ouk echei aphesin eis ton aiōna, alla enochos estin aiōniou hamartēmatos.*

Literal English: “But whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit does not have forgiveness [ἄφεσιν, *aphesin*: forgiveness / remission] into the age [εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, *eis ton aiōna*: into / unto the age], but is answerable for an eternal sin [αἰωνίου ἁμαρτήματος, *aiōniou hamartēmatos*: of an eternal sin].”

The idiom containing “age” gives an emphatic denial; it does not specify a period after which forgiveness resumes. “Answerable” distinguishes being held accountable for wrongdoing from the inward feeling of guilt. It does not reduce the passage to a financial debt or remove its seriousness.[21]

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[19] Sirach, prologue, lines 21–22 (NRSVUE). The grandson’s prologue distinguishes the Hebrew work from his Greek translation and applies the difficulty of translation to other scriptural books as well.

[20] SBLGNT, Mark 3:28. The future passive *aphethēsetai* is “will be forgiven”; the NIV’s “can be forgiven” is a translation decision, not an alternative Greek tense. The inclusive expression “sons of human beings” concerns humanity, not males alone.

[21] Robert G. Bratcher and Eugene A. Nida, *A Handbook on the Gospel of Mark* (1961), commentary on 3:29–30, excerpt hosted by the American Bible Society’s Translation Insights and Perspectives (TIPs); William D. Mounce, online Greek dictionary, s.v. “enochos.” The handbook explains the age-idiom as an emphatic temporal denial. Compare Mark 11:14 and the distinct “until the end of the age” wording in Matthew 28:20.

Mark 3:30

Greek: ὅτι ἔλεγον· Πνεῦμα ἀκάθαρτον ἔχει.

Romanization: *Hoti elegon: pneuma akatharton echei.*

Literal English: "Because they were saying, 'An unclean spirit he has.' "

The NIV uses "impure" for *akatharton*. Mark's explanation joins the warning to the accusation already being made.[22]

The language is forceful. The breadth of forgiveness heightens the exception without becoming empty rhetoric, and the Greek does not remove the severity. The warning concerns what these people are already saying about Jesus's work. What its denial of forgiveness means for them remains a question inside the translated words.

The final phrase also resists an easy resolution. The critical SBLGNT reads "eternal sin"; the Textus Receptus, the Greek text underlying the King James Version, reads "eternal judgment." The difference is in the noun, not a softer temporal statement. "Eternal sin" does not itself specify a punishment, but it does speak of being answerable for wrongdoing. Neither a complete theory of punishment nor a purely inward account of blocked healing is contained in those words alone. Their meaning is sought within the story, the wider scriptural witness, and the continuing experience of repentance, mercy, and consequence.[23]

The saying in Syriac

The Peshitta offers another witness to the reception of this saying. It is the traditional Syriac version of the Bible; Syriac is a literary form of Aramaic. Its version of Mark lets us hear how an Aramaic-speaking Christian community received the warning, rather than recovering a transcript of Jesus's speech. The following Syriac is quoted from the Peshitta, with vowel marks omitted. The romanization is a reading aid, and the literal English is supplied for this essay—not quoted from an unidentified translator.[24]

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[22] SBLGNT, Mark 3:30; Bratcher and Nida, commentary on 3:29–30. The imperfect *elegon* supplies the explanation "they were saying." Neither it nor the aorist subjunctive "blasphemes" in verse 29 supplies a clause promising forgiveness once the saying stops.

[23] Bratcher and Nida, commentary on Mark 3:29–30, discusses the critical reading *hamartēmatos* ("sin") and the Textus Receptus reading *kriseōs* ("judgment"). The variation does not by itself establish a motive for a scribal change or the history of every witness. For the ancient judicial range of *enochos*, compare Mark 14:64 and Matthew 5:21.

[24] Peshitta, Mark 3:29–30, British and Foreign Bible Society text displayed by Dukhrana Biblical Research, with George A. Kiraz's SEDRA analysis. The complete Syriac verses are reproduced without vowel and pronunciation marks or the final verse punctuation; word order and consonantal spelling are retained. Romanization is a simplified conventional reading aid, not reconstructed Galilean pronunciation. The literal English and explanatory brackets are supplied for this essay. The source's named English translations are comparison aids, not the authors of our rendering. The Peshitta's final noun concerns judgment; the SBLGNT's concerns sin. See also the *Gorgias Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Syriac Heritage*, "Peshitta," on the distinct Old and New Testament translation histories. Holiness and impurity are opposing descriptions of the spirit here, not a claim that every state of ritual impurity is moral evil.

Peshitta, Mark 3:29

Syriac: ܡܢ ܕܢ ܕܡ ܚܣܐ ܠܥ ܡܢ ܪܘܚܐ ܩ ܐܠ ܪܘܚܐ ܩܕܫܐ ܠܥ ܠܥܠܡ ܠܝܬ ܠܗ ܫܒܩܢܐ ܐܠܐ ܕ ܒܪܝܬ ܗ ܕܝܢܐ ܕܥܠܡ

Romanization: *Man dēn da-ngaddep ʿal rūḥā d-qudšā, layt leh šubqānā l-ʿālam; ʾellā mḥayyab hū l-dīnā da-l-ʿālam.*

Literal English: "But whoever blasphemes against the Spirit of holiness [ܪܘܚܐ ܕܩܕܫܐ, *rūḥā d-qudšā*: Spirit of holiness], there is no forgiveness for him [ܫܒܩܢܐ, *šubqānā*: forgiveness / remission] forever [ܠܥܠܡ, *l-ʿālam*: for the age; conventionally, forever]; rather, he is liable to judgment that is forever [ܕܝܢܐ ܕܥܠܡ, *l-dīnā da-l-ʿālam*: to judgment that is forever]."

Peshitta, Mark 3:30

Syriac: ܡܛ ܐܡܪ ܗܘܐ ܪܘܚܐ ܛܢܦܬܐ ܐܝܬ ܒܗ

Romanization: *Meṭul d-āmrīn hwaw, d-rūḥā ṭanpṯā ʾīt beh.*

Literal English: "Because they were saying that an impure spirit [ܪܘܚܐ ܛܢܦܬܐ, *rūḥā ṭanpṯā*: an impure spirit] is in him."

The repeated word *rūḥā*, spirit, makes the opposing descriptions audible: the source named holy in the warning is called impure in the accusation. The denial of forgiveness follows, with *šubqānā*, a word also used for remission, including remission of debt. *L-ʿālam* has the word-for-word shape "for the age," while functioning here as "forever." At the end of the warning, the Peshitta speaks of judgment rather than sin. That wording is attested in the Syriac text; it is not a judgment added by our English translation. The precise history of the difference from the critical Greek remains a question for textual research.[25]

The Greek *aiōn* has its own history, with senses including a lifetime, an age, and a world-order. It is the source of English *eon*, through Latin. The Greek and Aramaic expressions have different linguistic histories, yet both use age-language to express enduring time. Their resemblance concerns meaning and translation, not a shared etymological root. Mark's "into the age" and Matthew's "this age" and "the age to come" bring a temporal horizon into the saying. The interest of these expressions is not that a root word settles the meaning of eternity. They invite a further question: when we say that something lasts,

[25] Peshitta Mark 3:29–30, BFBS text displayed by Dukhrana, with Kiraz's SEDRA analysis; Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon, entries *šwbqn* and *ʿlm*. The former, senses 2–3, cites Peshitta Deuteronomy 15:1 for remission. The latter records established perpetuity expressions. "For the age" is a word-by-word reading aid for *l-ʿālam*, not a claim that the idiom supplies an endpoint. The exact route from a Greek exemplar through translation and revision to the Peshitta's judgment-reading is not established here. Old and New Testament Peshitta histories differ; no new Old Syriac collation is claimed.

what are we imagining remains the same? The duration asserted by a saying and the way a life carries its past belong to the inquiry together.[26]

Forgiveness, turning, and responsibility

Our English words bring other associations into the question of what forgiveness means. In the Lord's Prayer, Matthew has "forgive us our debts" (6:12, NIV), while Luke begins "Forgive us our sins" and then uses language of indebtedness, as the NIV's Greek-text footnote explains (11:4). The noun for forgiveness in Mark 3:29, *aphesis*, likewise belongs to the language of release and remission. Pardon, freedom from a burden, and the restoration of a relationship can illuminate one another without being the same thing. Divine forgiveness concerns a person's relation to God; reconciliation between people also requires attention to what has happened between them, and restored trust cannot simply be pronounced into being.[27]

Jewish reflection joins seeking mercy to how we treat another person. Ben Sira, a Jewish teacher writing in Jerusalem in the early second century BCE, says, "Forgive your neighbor the wrong he has done" (Sirach 28:2, NRSVUE), then connects that act with asking forgiveness in prayer. Later rabbinic teaching distinguishes wrongs against God from wrongs against another person: the latter are not atoned for by the Day of Atonement alone, "until one has appeased one's fellow" (Mishnah Yoma 8:9; translation supplied from Hebrew). A religious act does not simply discharge the responsibility to the person harmed. The same passage ends with Rabbi Akiva, a teacher of Roman-era Judea in the late first and early second centuries CE, addressing Israel: "Who purifies you? Your Father in heaven." Divine care and the obligation to the injured person sound together. The hope of purification does not make the work of repair unnecessary, and the demand for repair does not exhaust what the tradition says about mercy.[28]

The possibility of turning remains a searching question within that inheritance: wrongdoing can become deeply established, and mercy cannot be understood without considering

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[26] Mounce, s.vv. "aion" and "aionios"; Merriam-Webster, s.v. "eon," word history; Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon, *ʿlm*. Greek and Aramaic expressions are associated by translation and usage, not a common etymological root. Mark's *eis ton aiōna* is singular; Matthew 12:32 explicitly names this age and the coming one. Their temporal force is not a claim that the phrases have identical grammatical structures. Lexical histories open questions of perspective; they do not alone determine an ancient philosophy of time or the final scope of pardon.

[27] Matthew 6:12; Luke 11:4 and its NIV Greek-text footnote. For *aphesis*, see Mounce, s.v. "aphesis"; compare release from captivity in Luke 4:18 with forgiveness of sins in Luke 24:47. These are contextual uses of a shared noun, not interchangeable definitions.

[28] Sirach 28:1–7, especially 28:2 (NRSVUE); Mishnah Yoma 8:9, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre, where the passage is displayed as 8:7 [9]. The English clause from Yoma is a rendering supplied here of *ʿad she-yeraṣṣeh et ḥavero*. Its setting concerns atonement and obligation to the person wronged, not a requirement to restore an unsafe relationship. The unit ends with Rabbi Akiva addressing Israel and describing God's purification through Ezekiel 36:25 and Jeremiah 17:13. The English question and answer are translated for this project. For orientation to Ben Sira, see the USCCB introduction to Sirach; for Akiva's period, see "Akiba ben Joseph," *Jewish Encyclopedia*, whose traditional biographical details are not all adopted here.

what a life has become. Later Jewish reflection includes severe accounts of hardening as well as invitations to return.[29]

Interpretations over time

The possibility of changed understanding brings us back to the people in Mark. Their accusation precedes Jesus's summons; verse 30 explains why he gives the warning. If they recognize that they have misunderstood what is happening, what becomes possible? Such recognition might open into repentance—a changed direction rather than only a revised opinion. Would that turning show the warning accomplishing its purpose, or how would it stand in relation to the judgment pronounced? Mark does not tell us how they respond. Christian interpreters have returned to these questions through different understandings of repentance, mercy, and judgment.

John Chrysostom asks whether even repentance would be ineffective, then writes, "For even this was forgiven upon repentance" (*Homily 41*, §5). He says some who made the accusation subsequently believed. Yet he also describes grave punishment, and his homily contains anti-Jewish polemic that interprets collective suffering punitively. His hopeful sentence belongs to that troubling larger account. He is a human interpreter whose insights and harmful judgments both require attention.[30]

Augustine of Hippo, bishop and theologian in late-fourth- and early-fifth-century North Africa, identifies the decisive condition with final impenitence: refusal of repentance maintained until death. For the living, however, he insists, "For we are not to despair of any" (*Sermon 71*, §21). The thirteenth-century theologian Thomas Aquinas takes up this reading as a warning against reaching that condition. He also distinguishes rejection of the means of pardon from a limit on an "all-powerful and merciful God" (*Summa theologiae*, II–II, q.14, aa.1, 3). Neither removes final judgment, but both leave reason to hesitate before declaring a living person unreachable.[31]

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[29] Moses Maimonides (1138–1204), an influential Jewish philosopher and legal scholar, *Mishneh Torah*, Laws of Repentance 6:3; compare 2:9 on restitution and seeking pardon for interpersonal wrongs. He allows that grave, deliberate wrongdoing can result in a judgment by which "repentance is withheld from him" (translation supplied from Hebrew). The account includes Pharaoh and Isaiah 6:10: this is judicial hardening, not merely an inward obstacle. His earlier main-text discussion is retained here to keep that substantive counterpoint without interrupting the transition to Mark's interpreters. It does not describe what all Jesus's contemporaries believed.

[30] John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 41.5, translated by Prevost, revised by Riddle. He writes: "For even this was forgiven upon repentance. Many at least of those who said these words believed afterward, and all was forgiven them." His report that some accusers later believed is part of his interpretation; Mark itself does not narrate their later response. The same section speaks of punishment in this life and the next and applies it polemically to Jewish collective suffering.

[31] Augustine, *Sermon 71* (21 in the NPNF/New Advent sequence), §§20–21, translated by R. G. MacMullen; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* II–II, q.14, aa.1, 3, translated by the Fathers of the English Dominican Province. Augustine writes: "But this impenitence or impenitent heart may not be pronounced upon, as long as a man lives in the flesh." Aquinas likewise says, in a.3, reply to objection 1: "We should despair of no man in this life, considering God's omnipotence and mercy." Augustine counsels hope while a person remains alive; Aquinas distinguishes final impenitence from a sin that excludes the ordinary means of remission.

John Calvin, sixteenth-century Reformation theologian based in Geneva, draws the boundary around knowing rejection of recognized truth. Those who enter this condition, he says, "never have any desire towards repentance." His reading is not that God refuses a repentant person; it is that repentance will not arise.[32]

The Catholic Catechism also takes refusal seriously, affirming "There are no limits to the mercy of God" (§1864) before describing rejection of repentance and possible final loss. The nineteenth-century Scottish writer and preacher George MacDonald presses further, refusing to regard the condition as "a fixed, a final condition" (*It Shall Not Be Forgiven*). Whether resistance can itself ultimately change is where these readings diverge.[33]

Each account brings something consequential to the saying: a distinction between ignorance and knowing rejection, a boundary at death, or trust in a further possibility of transformation. These are efforts to understand the warning within a larger vision of God and human life. A dictionary cannot decide between them, and an argument depends on what we bring to its premises. Interpretation involves attention to the particular saying, the life and teaching to which it belongs, and the experience through which mercy and responsibility become more than concepts.

The warning and the work of hearing

Matthew's parallel states that forgiveness will not come "either in this age or in the age to come" (12:32, NIV). This is a substantial reason for taking the warning's finality seriously. A compassionate purpose can coexist with a conviction that the danger is irreversible. That reading deserves an answer, not a diagnosis of closed-mindedness. Equally, hope for transformation cannot simply insert "only while the refusal continues" into the sentence. The words retain their force even as we continue to ask how they address a human life.[34]

Mark 4 takes us further into the question of hearing. After the parable of the sower, the Twelve and others around Jesus ask about the parables. He speaks of the secret of God's

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[32] John Calvin, *Commentary on a Harmony of the Evangelists, Matthew, Mark, and Luke*, translated by William Pringle, commentary on Matthew 12:31–32 and the Synoptic parallels. Knowing, malicious repudiation and divinely imposed hardening that prevents a later desire to repent are premises of Calvin's interpretation; Mark does not explicitly report the accusers' private recognition of the truth.

[33] *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, §1864; George MacDonald, "It Shall Not Be Forgiven," in *Unspoken Sermons*. MacDonald's separate discussion of an age or era occurs in "Light," not in the sermon quoted here. MacDonald makes the relation between severity and mercy explicit: "But the very word that told them of the unpardonable state in which they were, was just the one form the voice of mercy could take in calling on them to repent. They must hear and be afraid." His account is a theological interpretation, not evidence that Mark's idiom contains an endpoint; he also assumes an inward recognition of goodness that Mark does not expressly narrate.

[34] Matthew 12:31–32. The phrase excludes both the present age and the coming age; a restoration beyond both would require a further theological argument, not merely a different dictionary gloss for "age."

kingdom being given to them and of those outside receiving everything in parables. Then, with the words "so that," he brings an ancient voice into the exchange:

> "they may be ever seeing but never perceiving, and ever hearing but never understanding; otherwise they might turn and be forgiven!"
>
> — Mark 4:12, NIV, drawing on Isaiah 6:9–10.[35]

Jesus is speaking within a stream of scriptural memory and interpretation. Isaiah's words belong to a prophetic commission in which the failure to hear and the threat of judgment are grave realities. Now they are spoken again, among people asking about a teaching. What might it mean to hear them there? Does "otherwise" describe an exclusion, expose the condition of hearing without understanding, or press upon the hearers the possibility of turning? What might compassion be doing through such a quotation—not outside its severity, but within it?

The same chapter places a lamp where its light can be seen and speaks of hidden things being brought into the open. It also describes Jesus teaching through parables in relation to what people could receive, while continuing to explain them to his disciples. Those closest to him do not simply possess understanding; they ask, listen, and need help. Parabolic teaching can both reveal and expose an inability to hear. Might the quotation from Isaiah bring this condition before the hearers so that they encounter it in themselves, rather than only recognize it in someone else?

There is a familiar Buddhist image for this difference. The *Dhammapada* compares long association with a wise person without understanding to a spoon that cannot taste the soup; the next verse compares swift understanding to a tongue that can. Closeness to a teaching and realization of it are not the same. The image need not become another division of people into fixed kinds. It can ask what our own familiarity has allowed us to understand—and what we still have not tasted.[36]

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[35] Mark 4:1–34, especially 10–13, 21–29, and 33–34, drawing on Isaiah 6:9–10. Mark's form ends in forgiveness; Isaiah's language speaks of healing. The quotation is an instance of scriptural reception, not a word-for-word identity across the two books and languages. Isaiah's commission includes judgment and devastation; the contemplative hearing does not remove that context. Mark's "so that" and "otherwise" remain visible rather than being replaced with a preferred paraphrase. Questions about their force and possible compassionate purpose are interpretive proposals, not a claim that divine concealment or prophetic judgment has been disproved. The disciples' need for explanation also cautions against equating every failure to understand with deliberate refusal. The seed comparison does not establish a theory that human insight is independent of God.

[36] *Dhammapada* 64–65, translated by Acharya Buddharakkhita, Access to Insight. The preceding verse, 63, commends recognition of one's own lack of understanding; the spoon/tongue contrast is not used here as a permanent diagnosis of particular people. Aaron recalls Thích Nhất Hạnh using this image, but a specific recording or page in his work has not been located in this pass. The essay therefore attributes the image to the attested canonical text rather than inventing a quotation from him.

In Mark's image of the growing seed, the sower sleeps and rises while growth takes place beyond his understanding (4:26–29). We can attend, question, practice, and help create conditions for understanding, but can we command the moment in which a teaching becomes clear? Willingness matters without being an explanation of everything that opens a heart. If compassion is our ground, perhaps the question becomes how teaching can nourish that opening, including through words that confront us. Mark's language of concealment does not disappear. It remains within this inquiry into why a teaching reaches one person, seems not to reach another, and may be heard differently at another time.

Reason can carry us into this tension. It can test what follows from the words, expose hidden premises, and keep us from treating preference as interpretation. But it need not force every religious utterance to operate on one level of description or yield an abstract system free of paradox. We bring language study, reason, history, experience, and contemplative insight together in seeking a meaningful, practicable understanding. A seeming contradiction is not permission to make the text mean anything; it is sometimes the place where our first categories prove too narrow.

What changes when we hear the saying as an address is not necessarily its truth, but our position in relation to it. Before it becomes an answer about someone else's destiny, it can become a question about our own way of seeing. We need not settle everything about eternity before allowing the words to reach the part of our lives that has not yet learned to listen.

4. When certainty closes the heart

Clinging to a view, looking deeply

Clinging to a view is not the same as reasoning carefully or holding a conviction. The danger begins when keeping a judgment becomes more important than discovering what is true. The scribes' description of Jesus's work gives that danger a concrete form: liberation is named evil and becomes something to resist rather than receive. Dogmatism gives this attachment a doctrinal form. We judge everything by the teaching as we have understood it, but no longer allow what happens, or what another person tells us, to question that understanding.

The Order of Interbeing places this danger within its First Mindfulness Training, which commits practitioners to transforming dogmatism and the violence it can produce, including attachment to Buddhist doctrines. The Second Training turns toward the practice

through which understanding develops: “compassionate listening, deep looking, and letting go of notions.” It says, “Truth is found in life.” This is not an instruction to stop studying. It asks that study remain in contact with what happens within us and around us, rather than become an accumulation that leaves our way of seeing untouched.[37]

Deep looking can begin very concretely. What did I hear this person say, and what did I assume they meant? What fear or loyalty makes one explanation easy to accept and another hard to consider? What happens to the people affected when I act on my view? We do not answer by announcing that every view is equally true. We stay with the words, the encounter, and its effects long enough to notice something our first understanding missed. An insight matters because it can change how we listen and what we do.

Some Buddhist scripture works directly with the limits of fixed designation. In Thích Nhất Hạnh’s translation of the *Diamond Sutra*, the bodhisattva’s commitment is “we must lead all these beings to nirvana”; yet the passage also says, “we do not, in truth, think that a single being has been liberated.” The instruction to liberate beings is not withdrawn. What is questioned is the grasping of a separate self, person, or living being. Words that guide compassionate action can also become fixed notions that obstruct understanding. The teaching asks us neither to abandon the work nor to make its language immune to inquiry.[38]

The comparison asks how words can guide us toward understanding and also become fixed notions that obstruct it. The expression in Mark 3 does not have the same apparently contradictory structure as this passage from the *Diamond Sutra*. Yet both can bring us to examine the understanding with which we first approached them. Reason and contemplation can work together here, revealing not only what our words express but what our use of them may conceal.

The Babylonian Talmud gives openness another concrete discipline. Its account of disagreement between the schools of Hillel and Shammai recognizes both as expressing words of the living God, yet directs practice according to Hillel’s school. The explanation concerns how that school taught: its members studied both positions and “put the words of the House of Shammai before their own” (Eruvin 13b; translation supplied here). The other voice was given a place within their own teaching. A ruling could still be made

[37] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, First, “Openness,” and Second, “Non-Attachment to Views.” The quoted phrases from the Second Training are exact excerpts, not a combined sentence. Its full text connects learning, collective wisdom, compassionate listening, deep looking, letting go of notions, and lifelong observation. Deep looking is not private feeling treated as self-validating revelation, nor is it the accumulation of propositions alone. The concrete questions in the essay are its own application.

[38] *The Diamond That Cuts Through Illusion* (*Vajracchedikā Prajñāpāramitā Sūtra*), translated by Thích Nhất Hạnh, official Plum Village text, first instructions to Subhuti after his question about the awakened mind. The two excerpts retain the contrast between the commitment to liberation and not grasping a separately existing being. The following passage explicitly concerns notions of self, person, living being, and life span. The comparison is not evidence that Mark 3 is historically a Buddhist koan or that every apparent contradiction can be assigned automatically to two truths. The complete published commentary volume has not been read in this revision.

without requiring that voice to disappear. Can we understand an account from within before deciding what to accept or reject?[39]

The Muslim theologian Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī, from Persia in the eleventh and early twelfth centuries, approaches another part of this question through his account of Sufi practice. He had studied its teachings, yet found that knowing them was not the same as undergoing the change they described:

> "To define health and satiety, to penetrate their causes and conditions, is quite another thing from being well and satisfied."
>
> — Al-Ghazālī, *The Confessions of Al Ghazzali*, "Sufism," translated by Claud Field.[40]

His inquiry turns toward his own life, including the motives behind his teaching. The question is not only whether he can explain a path, but whether he is walking it. Understanding must reach the person who understands.

Mark directs the concern about failed recognition toward the disciples too. Jesus asks them, "Are your hearts hardened?" and "[D]on't you remember?" (8:17–18, NIV), then continues to teach them. Later they try to stop someone driving out demons in Jesus's name because "he was not one of us"; Jesus answers, "Do not stop him" (9:38–39, NIV). Attachment to belonging threatens to obstruct the work they claim to serve. Difficulty in recognizing what is good belongs within the circle of disciples as well as beyond it.[41]

The disciples' misunderstandings prevent us from assigning failed recognition only to those who challenge Jesus. Those closest to him also struggle to understand. The scribes, the disciples, and the members of his family meet what is happening through different histories and commitments; no single response gives a complete account of any of them.

Paul and changed seeing

Paul's life gives the possibility of change particular weight. He recalls, "I persecuted the church of God and tried to destroy it," before describing God's revelation of the Son (Galatians 1:13–16, NIV). Acts tells the change through blindness, restored sight, and Ananias's

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[39] Babylonian Talmud, Eruvin 13b, passage beginning with Rabbi Abba's report in the name of Samuel, Hebrew/Aramaic text at Mechon Mamre. The account describes the schools disagreeing for three years, affirms both schools' words, and directs practice according to Hillel. The English clause about presenting the other school first is translated for this project. The later compilation is not a transcript of the first-century exchange in Mark. Recognition of another view's religious standing does not mean every claim is equally true in every respect.

[40] Al-Ghazālī, *The Confessions of Al Ghazzali*, translated by Claud Field (London: John Murray, 1909), "Sufism," p. 41; the examination of teaching motives follows on pp. 43–44. The argument retains his commitments to God, revelation, and judgment. The English translation, not an Arabic critical edition, was consulted.

[41] Mark 8:14–21; 9:38–41; compare 6:52. The man in 9:38 acts in Jesus's name while standing outside the disciples' group. The passage challenges their attempted prohibition without making every claimed healing self-authenticating.

words: “you may see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit” (9:17, NIV). The person who had worked to destroy the community comes to recognize what he had opposed.[42]

First Timothy qualifies its account of mercy: “I acted in ignorance and unbelief” (1:13, NIV). This canonical portrayal has disputed authorship and should not simply be merged with Paul’s own account in Galatians or with Acts’ narrative. The distinction between ignorance and knowing rejection matters, and none of these passages establishes that Paul made the particular accusation in Mark. His life does not cancel the warning. It does prevent destructive religious opposition from becoming, by itself, proof that a person cannot change. Paul’s own severe words against a different gospel also keep him from becoming a simple emblem of openness: transformation does not remove every hard boundary from a person’s convictions.[43]

Nor does receptivity have to begin as an achievement a person produces alone. An encounter can interrupt the understanding through which everything else has been interpreted. Paul attributes his change of direction to God’s revelation of the Son; Acts connects restored sight with the gift of the Spirit. “If we refuse to see, we do not see” remains a searching formulation, but refusal need not be the last thing that happens to us. What becomes possible when we encounter what our settled understanding could not receive?

That question concerns transformation, not automatic absolution. Changed perception does not erase harm, establish divine forgiveness, or oblige another person to restore trust. A changing person can bear a lasting consequence. Responsibility and the possibility of becoming different remain together.

The warning turns toward its interpreters

Clinging to a view can also shape Christian interpretation. We can defend an account of goodness while refusing to hear those harmed by its application. Even forgiveness can be used this way when it requires an injured person to stop speaking before responsibility has been acknowledged. A boundary against further harm is not closed-heartedness, and reluctance to trust a teacher’s claimed healing is not blasphemy.

The Gospel’s own test of profession is demanding. Matthew warns about those who say “Lord, Lord” (7:21, NIV), including people who claim powerful deeds in Jesus’s name. In the judgment scene of chapter 25, the king recalls being fed, welcomed, clothed, and visited

[42] Galatians 1:13–16; Acts 9:1–19. Paul’s letter and Acts’ narrative are distinct literary witnesses. Galatians 1:8–9 supplies the counterweight concerning Paul’s own severe boundary against a different gospel.

[43] 1 Timothy 1:12–16; on the disputed authorship of the Pastoral Epistles, see the USCCB introduction to 1 Timothy. The qualification concerning ignorance cannot establish either ignorance or knowing rejection on the part of Mark’s scribes.

in sickness and prison. The people he commends are surprised: when did they see him in such need? His answer brings recognition into the acts of care themselves:

> "whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."
>
> — Matthew 25:40, NIV.[44]

Those who failed to offer such care also ask when they saw him. The scene ends with eternal punishment and eternal life, not merely approval of kindness. The identity of those called the least has been interpreted in different ways, but the narrative makes one demand unmistakable: profession does not replace a response to the life before us. Recognition may become apparent in what we have done, or failed to do, rather than in the confidence of our religious claims.

Christian anti-Judaism makes the stakes historical as well as personal. In its account of the German churches under Nazism, the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum records that "traditional interpretations of religious scriptures seemed to support these prejudices." Inherited Christian teaching, Nazi racial ideology, state power, and different forms of complicity and resistance belong to this history. Christian teaching was not its single cause, but its part cannot be omitted. Nor can the suffering of Jewish people be reduced to a lesson about someone else's spiritual growth.[45]

The responsibility includes questioning interpretations that enabled people and institutions to disregard Jewish lives. It also includes correction: the Second Vatican Council's declaration *Nostra aetate* §4 states that Jews "should not be presented as rejected or accursed by God." The declaration does not undo earlier injury, but shows that authoritative teaching can restrain harm as well as be used to sustain it. The problem is not simply that there is a doctrine. It is whether that doctrine and its application remain answerable to the truth and human dignity they claim to serve.[46]

The antidote to dogmatism is therefore not indifference. It includes study, prayer, listening, concrete care, and willingness to change what we do when harm becomes visible. It also leaves room for honest disagreement. Another person's refusal to accept our interpretation does not establish that their heart is closed. The same test returns upon a compassionate reading of Mark: if we dismiss every difficult verse or contrary interpretation

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[44] Matthew 7:15–27; 25:31–46. The narrative setting, acts of care, both groups' questions, verse 40, and the final contrast are presented together. The USCCB note to Matthew 25:31–46 records disagreement about the identity of "the least" and favors disciples acting as missionaries. The broader ethical application here is not presented as the only available exegesis.

[45] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "The German Churches and the Nazi State," sections "Background," "Protestant Churches in Nazi Germany," and "Summary." This is a historical synthesis, not a primary document from the Nazi period. It describes differences among Christian responses as well as the contribution of inherited anti-Jewish teaching.

[46] Second Vatican Council, *Nostra aetate*, October 28, 1965, §4. The declaration rejects collective Jewish responsibility for Jesus's death and condemns antisemitism; its doctrinal commitments should not be confused with an abandonment of Christian particularity.

as a failure of compassion, we have protected our own view from the encounter we ask of others.

5. Humanity without distance from the divine

The call to look again does not stop with those whom Jesus addresses. It also concerns how we see Jesus himself. Reverence can bring us close to a life, but it can also place that life at such a distance that we no longer hear a person speaking to other people. Then a warning becomes a timeless classification before we have attended to the act of address. Recovering the human encounter does not weaken the words; it restores the relation in which their force is first felt.

A human teacher, a human transmission

The teaching reaches us through lives as well as words. Matthew retains the exchange about Jesus's power; Luke places the warning beside the promise that "the Holy Spirit will teach you at that time what you should say" (12:12, NIV). The different settings guide different acts of understanding. *Dei verbum*, the Second Vatican Council's constitution on divine revelation, recognizes the evangelists as "selecting some things from the many which had been handed on" (§19), while affirming the truth of the Gospels. Interpretation already participates in how the tradition is given, not simply in what later readers add.[47]

Jesus's humanity belongs within this stream. Luke says that he "grew in wisdom" (2:52, NIV); John shows him "tired as he was from the journey" (4:6, NIV). Mark gives us prayer, anger, grief, questions, and encounters under pressure. These are not incidental concessions to a human appearance. They are part of the life through which his teaching is encountered. A human teacher speaks to particular hearers, with words that may console in one moment and confront in another.[48]

To attend to this humanity is not to take something from his divinity. The Catholic Catechism itself holds together "true God and true man" (§464), and, quoting the Second Vatican Council, affirms his human thought and says that "with a human heart he loved" (§470). That tradition makes claims beyond describing a divinely inspired teacher, but it also gives genuine humanity a central place. Human thought, love, and relationship are not what must be removed before the divine can be encountered. Taking incarnation seriously brings us toward the particular person speaking under accusation, not away from him into an account of truth without a human voice.[49]

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[47] Matthew 12:22–32; Luke 12:8–12; Second Vatican Council, *Dei verbum*, November 18, 1965, §19. The constitution recognizes selection, synthesis, and explanation while affirming that the evangelists told the truth about Jesus; it is not an endorsement of every possible account of fallibility.

[48] Luke 2:52; John 4:6; Mark 1:35; 3:5. These texts describe human life and circumstance; they do not establish any particular claim that Jesus committed a moral or doctrinal error.

[49] *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, §§464, 467, 470–474. Section 470 quotes the Second Vatican Council's *Gaudium et spes*, §22. The adjacent treatment of human knowledge is qualified by the Catechism's affirmation of divine knowledge; the humanity claim should not be isolated from those commitments.

The only child and the whole world

The language of divine sonship can seem to place Jesus at an unreachable distance. John calls him God's "one and only Son" (3:16, NIV), yet also speaks of those who receive him becoming "children of God" (1:12, NIV). These statements are not identical, but neither is the second insignificant. The Gospel's particular claim about Jesus accompanies an invitation into relationship with God.[50]

The word *monogenēs*, traditionally translated "only begotten," identifies the only or unique one in a relationship; in John 3:16 it refers to Jesus. Alongside that particular claim, the image of an only child can open another question about love. Could each person be loved *as if an only child*, with a care that does not treat anyone as expendable? This is a contemplative extension of the image, not an account of where John's expression historically came from. It asks about the quality of a love that the same verse extends toward the world. An only child is not loved as one interchangeable instance of a category. The comparison invites care that sees a particular life, even when that care must confront what the person is doing.

The Buddhist *Discourse on Love* makes a related movement. In Thích Nhất Hạnh's translation, the example is "[j]ust as a mother loves and protects her only child at the risk of her own life." Such wholehearted loving-kindness is to be extended to all beings. Matthew's call to "love your enemies" (5:44, NIV), grounded in the Father's care for the evil and the good, offers a Christian point of encounter. Neither passage makes harmful conduct harmless. Both unsettle the division of care according to who belongs, who agrees, or who has become difficult to love.[51]

The people addressed in Mark remain within that field of care. Their accusation is serious, and Jesus can confront it without their humanity disappearing. His concern need not depend on their agreement. The question is not whether their words matter, but whether those words become all that can be seen of them.

A person is more than a description

A statement about what someone has done can become the final account of who they are. This is not a choice between logic and insight. Careful reasoning can expose the hidden step from "this person did harm" to "this is all this person can ever be"; insight asks whether the description we are using is adequate to the living person before us. A

[50] John 3:16; 1:12–14; Mounce, s.v. "monogenes." The unique Son and those becoming children of God are not interchangeable referents. The only-child image developed here is a contemplative comparison, not a replacement translation of *monogenēs*.

[51] *Discourse on Love* (*Mettā Sutta*, Sutta Nipāta 1.8), translated by Thích Nhất Hạnh, official Plum Village text; Matthew 5:43–48. The Buddhist passage instructs practitioners to cultivate boundless loving-kindness; it does not make a claim about a creator God.

truthful account of harmful actions remains necessary without becoming an exhaustive account of a life.[52]

Thích Nhất Hạnh approaches historical and ultimate dimensions through the image of wave and water. The wave's arising and passing are not denied, but neither do they exhaust what the wave is. He cautions that "interbeing does not mean that everything is one or that everything is different." This invites attention to two forms of closure: identifying someone completely with a past act, or imagining that transformation produces an unrelated person with no responsibility for it. In relation to Mark, this does not establish that an eternal consequence is impossible. It helps us distinguish a person's act, the person who remains answerable for it, and the possibility of a different response. None should be made to disappear into the others.[53]

What lasts, and what changes?

The question of a different response brings time back into view. What does it mean for something to last? A warning is spoken in the present to people whose earlier judgments are shaping what they can receive. Those judgments may continue through repeated words, habits of fear, or the influence they have on others. If understanding changes, something else can grow from the same history. Continuation need not mean that an action and all its effects remain unchanged.

The question is how actions continue through changing conditions, and how new understanding enters those conditions. What is preserved, what is transformed, and what remains to be cared for?

Jewish Passover practice makes a past deliverance part of present identity and obligation. Mishnah Pesachim requires each person, in every generation, to regard themselves "as though they had come out of Egypt" (10:5; translation supplied from Hebrew). This later rabbinic formulation develops the first-person language of Exodus 13:8. The event is not simply over and absent; remembrance enters how life is lived now.[54]

Augustine offers a different but related attention to time in his *Confessions*: "a present of things past, a present of things present, and a present of things future" (XI.20.26). He locates these in memory, present awareness, and expectation. His attention to lived time

[52] The distinction here concerns the adequacy of a description, not a proposed alternative to logical consistency. From a present refusal it does not follow, without another premise, that refusal must always continue. Equally, the possibility of change does not establish forgiveness or eliminate an enduring consequence. Mark's temporal qualification still needs to be interpreted.

[53] Thích Nhất Hạnh, interviewed by Melvin McLeod, "This Is the Buddha's Love," *Shambhala Sun*, March 2006; republished by Plum Village. See the discussion of wave and water and the question about interpreting interbeing as universal oneness. The ethical application to continuing responsibility is a constructive comparison, not a quotation from the interview.

[54] Mishnah Pesachim 10:5, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre; compare Exodus 13:8. The English phrase is translated for this project. The obligation is personal in every generation; the later rabbinic text should not be treated as a transcript of Jesus's understanding of time.

coexists with his understanding of final impenitence: the same thinker still places a decisive boundary at death.[55]

John's Gospel speaks of someone who already "has eternal life," while retaining a future resurrection and judgment (5:24–29, NIV). In another image, a grain of wheat bears fruit through losing the form in which it stood alone (12:24). Within John this speaks of Jesus's death and the life it makes possible. We need not gather these different accounts into a single philosophy to notice their attention to life that is received, shared, and transformed, not only prolonged.[56]

The relation to a past action can change as well. Ezekiel says that when a person turns from wrongdoing, none of the former sins "will be remembered against them" (18:22, NIV). The Qur'an describes those who repent, believe, and do good as people "whose evil deeds Allah will change into good deeds" (25:70, translated by Mustafa Khattab). These texts speak of divine mercy, not a Buddhist account of karma. Yet each makes us ask what it means to carry a past without being confined to repeating it. The claim is not that the harm never happened, but that it need not exhaust the relation between the person, God, and the life still to be lived.[57]

Sister Annabel Laity (True Virtue), a British-born Buddhist nun and teacher in the Plum Village tradition, connects attention to time with regret and present responsibility: "The three times inter-are." Past action continues in its consequences; how we respond now helps form what comes next. Her discussion of regret turns toward acting differently in the present, not making the past unhappen. Transformation can mean entering responsibility more fully.[58]

The relation among the times matters alongside their duration. A past act is not changed into something that never happened, yet its continuation can involve remorse, repair, renewed harm, or a different way of living. These comparisons do not change Mark's

[55] Augustine, *Confessions* XI.20.26, translated by J. G. Pilkington; compare XI.28.37–38 on reciting a psalm. For final impenitence, see *Sermon 71*, §§20–21. His account of temporal experience does not itself imply forgiveness after death.

[56] John 5:24–29 and 12:23–26. The present possession of eternal life stands beside future resurrection and judgment. The grain image belongs to the announcement of Jesus's coming death and the following language of discipleship; it is not an assertion that Johannine resurrection and Buddhist continuation are one metaphysics.

[57] Ezekiel 18:21–32, especially 22–23, NIV; Qur'an 25:68–71, especially 70, Mustafa Khattab, *The Clear Quran*. Ezekiel links turning with right conduct and life. Qur'an 25 first gives severe warnings concerning wrongdoing, then speaks of repentance, faith, good action, and God's transforming mercy. The change of evil deeds into good has a history of interpretation not surveyed here; the essay does not decide whether every temporal or juridical consequence is removed. These are comparative questions about a changed relation to a real past, not claims that Abrahamic traditions teach Buddhist no-self or karma.

[58] Sister Annabel Laity (True Virtue), "The Three Dharma Seals," *The Mindfulness Bell* 74 (February 2017), section "The Three Times Inter-Are"; teaching given June 20, 2016, at Plum Village. The quoted sentence is Laity's, not an independently verified quotation from Thích Nhất Hạnh. The publisher's author record supplies her English origin and scholarly/monastic background.

"never." They bring us closer to the lives about which we are speaking when we ask what lasts, what changes, and what responsibility asks of us now.[59]

Compassion that is not merely reassurance

How we speak to someone becomes part of what happens next. A warning does not enter an empty space; it enters a life already shaped by fear, conviction, suffering, and hope. Its truth matters, and so do the way it is offered and the response it makes possible. The question is now close to the original encounter: can severe speech open a way toward recognition without reducing the hearer to the judgment being challenged?

Freedom of thought need not leave us silent before a harmful view. The Third Mindfulness Training of the Order of Interbeing joins respect for another person's freedom with helping to transform fanaticism and narrowness through "loving speech and compassionate dialogue." Its commitment "not to force others" is not a commitment never to challenge them. The distinction concerns whether speech helps understanding become possible or demands submission to the speaker.[60]

The Qur'an addresses Muhammad's work of inviting people to the way of God and places that work within a discipline of speech:

> "Call to your Lord's way with wisdom and good counsel, and conduct your argument with them in the best manner. Your Lord knows best who has strayed from his way, and he knows best those who are guided."
>
> — Qur'an 16:125, English translation supplied for this essay.[61]

The invitation is not without conviction: it calls people toward God. Yet conviction does not remove the responsibility to address another person wisely, or give the speaker complete knowledge of that person's relation to guidance.

An authentic warning draws attention to a real danger. It may need to be urgent, and its discomfort does not make it coercive. The Buddhist discourse to Prince Abhaya similarly describes speech that is "factual, true, beneficial, but unendearing & disagreeable to others," with attention to the proper time for speaking it (*Majjhima Nikāya* 58, translated by

[59] The comparison concerns lived memory, expectation, continuity, and responsibility, not a single ancient theory of time. On the danger of a neat Hebrew/Greek opposition, see Henri Blocher, "Yesterday, Today, Forever," especially pp. 185–90. The fact that later conditions arise from earlier ones does not prove that every karmic result lasts infinitely or that an unchanging guilt is transmitted forever. The status of the person before God, the persistence of harm, and the transformation of conduct must remain distinguishable.

[60] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, Third, "Freedom of Thought." Its prohibition of imposed belief belongs alongside its positive commitment to compassionate dialogue.

[61] Qur'an 16:125–128. The whole of verse 125 is given in an English translation supplied for this essay from the Arabic displayed by Alim, compared with Marmaduke Pickthall and Mustafa Khattab; it is not their verbatim wording. The invitation is to the Lord's way, and the final clauses locate fullest knowledge of guidance with God. The surrounding verses concern retaliation, restraint, and patience. No comprehensive Arabic commentary survey or specialist certification of the supplied translation is claimed. This later Islamic voice is not a historical source for Jesus's speech.

Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu). That discourse, too, arises around a severe judgment. Compassion is not identified simply with what sounds reassuring.[62]

Heard in this light, Jesus's warning may belong to compassion in action. Compassion need not mean continuing an exchange on terms that allow harm to go unchallenged. Sometimes it calls for an interruption, a boundary, or a refusal to let another person's account of events become the only one that can be heard. The care involved includes people affected by the exchange, not only the person whose words are challenged.

Whenever we speak from spiritual, moral, or institutional authority, our intention is only part of what matters. We must also attend to what is happening, to the person being addressed, and to the effects of our words. Dialogue is not always possible or wise. A person facing threats or coercion may need distance, support, or a firm boundary instead. Nonviolence asks how harm may be resisted without being reproduced, including how to protect the space in which others can speak and be heard.

Remaining in the teaching

Contemplative engagement carries attention into the act of interpretation. The question includes the one asking it. What needs to change may be not only a proposed answer, but how we listen, speak, and respond to someone we had already decided we understood. The warning can touch our own attachment rather than remain a means of classifying other people.[63]

It can also ask us, imaginatively and carefully, to stand in more than one place in the scene: among the crowd who may be influenced, with the disciples learning how to recognize what is good, with the scribes whose judgment is being challenged, and with Jesus speaking under accusation. This does not pretend access to anyone's private mind. It prevents us from remaining safely outside the encounter while deciding what it means for everyone else.

[62] *Majjhima Nikāya* 58, "Abhaya Sutta: To Prince Abhaya," translated by Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu (1997), Access to Insight edition revised November 30, 2013, third category in the sixfold account of speech. The opening concerns Devadatta and a severe prediction of hell and incurability. The comparison therefore distinguishes beneficial speech from agreeable speech; it does not dissolve judgment into reassurance.

[63] Thích Nhất Hạnh, "Bat Nha: a Koan." The letter's imagined first-person roles are literary devices within the teaching, not independent witness accounts. The proposed contemplative use of the scene does not exempt a historical or ethical claim from examination.

John gives this relation between teaching and lived understanding a direct expression:

> "If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples. Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."
>
> — John 8:31–32, NIV.[64]

The verb *menō* means to remain or abide. Knowing is joined to remaining in the word, not simply to possessing a settled explanation of it. In John's setting, the freedom concerns sin and the liberating work of the Son. The invitation has a practical depth: forgiveness, love, and repentance become known through the lives in which they are practiced. Study and inherited teaching belong to that process; so do the encounters that reveal where our understanding has not yet become action.

John also speaks of "whoever lives by the truth" coming into the light (3:21, NIV). The Greek phrase is ποιῶν τὴν ἀλήθειαν, *poiōn tēn alētheian*: literally, "doing the truth." Truth is not only something affirmed; it is enacted. An interpretation of mercy must become more than a persuasive account of mercy. Its meaning appears in whether we can tell the truth about harm, care for those affected, and remain willing to learn.[65]

6. The invitation before us

The warning has not become gentler, but the encounter around it has become more visible. We can hear the accusation being made, the people Jesus calls toward him, and the wider circle whose trust might be shaped by what is said. His response may seek to reach those making the accusation while also challenging its influence on others. Compassion need not be separate from the force of that response; it may be expressed through it. What sounded at first like a final classification of a person can also be heard as speech intended to do something within a life.

To hear in this way is to become involved. The saying no longer concerns only whether someone else has crossed a boundary beyond forgiveness. It asks how we recognize what is good, what we resist, and what becomes possible when an understanding we have defended begins to change. The parables, the disciples' questions, and the history of interpretation bring us back to the difference between having encountered a teaching and allowing it to reach us. Familiarity with the words does not mean that we have finished hearing them.

The question of what lasts also becomes more searching. An accusation can continue through the fears it creates, the actions it permits, or the possibilities it closes for someone else. A different understanding does not erase that history, but it can change how we participate in what follows. Repentance and repair belong to this continuation: the past

[64] John 8:31–36 (NIV); the audience in 8:31 is described as having believed, and the next verses concern slavery to sin and the Son's liberating work. The Greek says "you are really my disciples," not "you become my disciples."

[65] John 3:21; Greek *poiōn tēn alētheian*, "doing the truth." The full verse locates the deeds in God. The wording supports ethical enactment, not an account of private experience as the sole test of truth.

remains real without requiring us to repeat it. The force of “never” remains before us, alongside the question of how a person may come to hear differently. We need not settle every question of final judgment before becoming responsible for what our own words and actions sustain.

Humanizing Jesus does not require making him ordinary in the sense of insignificant. It means allowing his teaching to arise within a human life, grounded in time, place, culture, relationships, conflicts, grief, courage, and love. His Jewish inheritance belongs to that humanity, as do the people who shared it and understood it differently. The disciples, religious teachers, evangelists, and later interpreters belong to that arc of human experience. His divinity need not be protected by making that life less human. Reverence can bring us closer to these lives rather than place them beyond understanding.

An understanding of forgiveness can remain generous in its claims while becoming anemic in practice. We can defend mercy and fail to hear someone asking for accountability; we can defend truth while refusing an encounter that might deepen our understanding of it. Remaining in the teaching asks more than finding a formulation that no longer troubles us. It asks that understanding become visible in how we listen, acknowledge harm, make repair, and care for the lives before us. Whom have we already decided we understand—perhaps ourselves—and what might become possible if we listened again?

Translation acknowledgments

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